THE PARADOX OF AI AND THE BUSINESS MORAL COMPASS

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Artificial intelligence (AI) today occupies a paradoxical space in public imagination: it is both feared and revered—often for valid reasons. As AI systems grow more capable, society grapples with concerns about job displacement, data privacy, accountability, and the erosion of essential human skills. At the same time, AI promises unprecedented opportunities for advancing knowledge, alleviating human suffering e.g. through medical innovations, and solving complex global challenges. Amid these contrasting narratives, what becomes most important is not whether AI is inherently dangerous or beneficial, but whether we understand it and use it ethically and responsibly. This principle matters profoundly for business education as AI continues to shape the fabric of modern society.



Business schools must prepare graduates who are not only proficient users of AI, but thoughtful leaders capable of governing AI responsibly. Students must understand how AI reshapes corporate strategy, supply chains, labour markets, and stakeholder expectations. Yet they must also learn to challenge algorithmic biases and assess long-term societal consequences. As Peter Drucker famously said, "The greatest danger in times of turbulence is not the turbulence; it is to act with yesterday's logic."

At the Amrita School of Business, we are committed to nurturing human intelligence – both cognitive and emotional dimensions that draw on ethical principles hand-in-hand with AI skills. The moral compass points to a more sustainable and compassionate world. The qualities of compassion, empathy, trust and integrity must be intentionally cultivated so individuals working with AI function as discerning collaborators rather than passive dependents. Chancellor of Amrita Viswa Vidyapeetham and world-renown spiritual leader, Sri Mata Amritanandamayi Devi, says:

Education should spread light within and without. Education should equally develop discernment and contemplation.

By aligning human intelligence with ethical and compassionate outlook, AI becomes a tool that enhances rather than diminishes human agency. Real discernment can only come with the foundations of contemplation and the courage to ask the 'right' questions. For instance, in 2020, the UK's A-level grading algorithm scandal showed how uncritical reliance on AI can lead to harmful outcomes. The algorithm, intended to standardise grades during the pandemic, systematically downgraded students from disadvantaged schools, revealing embedded biases in the data and decision logic. This incident forced educators, regulators, and policymakers to confront the ethical stakes of AI deployment and highlighted why reflective human oversight and value-driven governance systems are essential.

To counter fears of being "dumbed down" or overwhelmed by AI, both learners and professionals must revisit foundational models of learning. We need to learn - 'how-to-learn' with AI. Learning is shaped by habits, values, and reflective inquiry. Habits such as questioning assumptions, seeking diverse viewpoints, and evaluating evidence are critical for interpreting AI-generated insights. Values such as honesty, integrity, empathy and transparency lead to trust. Students need to seek and declare the authenticity of their work. Reflection and contemplation will help them understand how their own biases and emotional responses influence learning outcomes.

Ultimately, the future of AI—and of business—depends on how we nurture human intelligence, ethics, and learning. It is time to embrace AI, and widen the door of opportunities. It is also time to move to more virtuous reflective learning models !

Yes, You have a friend in AI – but as a future business leader – you need to set the moral compass right—and hold yourself accountable to the path you choose!

